

What is your role?

Today I am an engineering manager.

And how long have you worked with software development?

9 years.

And do you use any AI tool in your work, in the software development process?

I do. I use Cursor and Cloud.

And how often do you use these tools?

Every day.

And in what types of activities do you usually use them?

Yeah, I use it to code, so, like, support in coding, right? Whether asking AI to code something specific or to code unit tests for something specific. Yeah, and also to understand the codebase, right? So, I have some question about how something works. Yeah, I ask the AI and it answers me and brings some pointers too.

And can you describe a recent case in which you used AI to solve an activity from beginning to end?

Sure, I was working on a rearchitecture of a form, and I used AI from the conception, so, like, I had my architectural ideas, I wrote an architecture document, and I used AI, more the planning models, to ask the AI to challenge my architecture, try to find flaws and everything at the moment of conception itself. Yeah, that helped me find some things, refine some things. And then later I used this refined plan as, well, I talked to my team, right? I presented the plan and so on, there was all this issue, we agreed and so on. And, yeah, after that I used this refined plan to ask AI to implement some generic hooks that followed this architecture. Yeah, and then I did one case, right? I rearchitected a component. Yeah, and then I used this component as a reference together with my architecture document to do the other refactors of my codebase. And then most of the other refactors after that were already with AI guiding.

Does this tool take your whole project and then it can make the codes based on it or not? Do you just keep sending things and it keeps doing them?

Yeah, I use Cursor more, because it has more of the graphical interface and I, a personal preference of mine, I like dealing more with the graphical interface than with the terminal. And it has access to all the files, right? It is a text editor like VSCode, it is a fork of VSCode. Yeah, so it has access to all the files there, all the code that you open inside it.

And when you need to make some alteration, some change there in your code, do you need to pass a prompt or do you have this freedom to go directly into your code and change it?

No, I can change it manually, if I want. Ah, or I can ask the AI to do it, so, the decision is really up to the person who is developing the task.

And do you use it more as support? Do you ask and then review everything it is doing, or do you ask for something and trust that it will do it?

Yeah, it depends on the use, okay? So, if I am making code that is useful, useful in the sense that it is code that will impact my customers in the end, I will review two, three, five times, what it generates and everything, but I also use it to generate personal projects. So, for example, ah, to have a better visualization of some data and so on. And then these are projects where I really ask it, ah, build a dashboard for me using these APIs because it is for my own use. So, it is not code that I need to maintain. Yeah, it can be a mess and that is okay, I just really need to use it there to have my view, my dashboards, and then in this case I do not review anything.

And when you use AI in a task, how do you define what needs to be done? Do you already have a template, some model of something, do you just ask it, it builds a certain template, or do you build this throughout the interactions?

It depends on the task. If it is a very specific task, for example, ah, I want, eh, my technical background is in front-end, right? So, my examples will also be aligned with this area. Yeah, for example, ah, I need this button, instead of opening a modal, actually, to be a pop-up. Then I will find, usually what I do is find the source code, so I will find where the pop-up is. Ah, the modal, I do not remember what the name was. And then I will put this as context and say: "Look, I need this to be changed to a modal, a pop-up." Yeah, if there is a more complex task, for example, ah, I need to open a side panel that will have data x, y and z and then when I click on the button it will go to another screen, anyway, it is something with a little more complexity, I use the planning models to generate the plan and the tasks and then later I switch to an agent model that then implements this plan with the tasks.

And has the use of AI changed the way you work and, if so, how?

It has changed a lot. Yeah, nowadays I, like, use AI a lot in my daily work. Simpler tasks I delegate a lot. Ah, and we also use AI review. So, when you have a pull request, you have AI reviewing your code. And sometimes they catch very interesting things. Ah, so, like, I think it changed both in the sense that it saves me a lot of time to delegate simple tasks, and also saves me future problems, because in this review stage it sometimes notices things that I missed.

And what difficulties do you find when using AI?

It hallucinates, right? So, sometimes it gets lost, there is the issue of the context problem. Sometimes the context, when the context starts to get very large, it starts to get very lost and hallucinate. And when it goes down the wrong path, it goes very, like. So, sometimes, it generates a lot of wrong code. Or generates very wrong things. And another problem is, I think it is this tacit knowledge that we have between teams, we have conventions and good practices that sometimes are not, but then it may be our mistake, right? But not all of them are translated into agent configuration documents. So sometimes you ask AI to do something and it does it and it is not wrong, but it is not the way we do it. So this is kind of the personalization with the team's practices, like.

Ah, so these configurations vary according to the team?

It is because we use a monorepo, right? So we have several teams in the same repository, several products. And we have more global agent configurations with some instructions, but it turns out that each team sometimes defines its own standards for how the code will be separated and then it would be up to each team to create its own agent configuration file too. Which is a little more work, right? You have to keep updating it all the time and everything. And then we do not do it 100%.

And how was your process of starting to use AI? Did you think it was easy, was it difficult? How was it for you to adapt to this new scenario?

Ah, it was medium, like. I do not have an early adopter profile, I am not the person who, ah, something new came out and I am there using it. So, like, I may have taken a while to start using it. Yeah, there was a very big incentive from the company, like, to have and make the tools available and encourage people to use them. Yeah, at the beginning I feel that my adoption was gradual, so I started with the tab completions, like, right? You are typing the code and the suggestion appears, then you press tab and it autocompletes. I started like that, then later I started testing it for the more annoying things, I do not know, I needed to change a string in 25 files. Okay, that is a replace, right? But anyway, those more annoying changes that you have to do. Then I started asking it to do this and so on. And then I started experimenting more, this issue of bigger changes and everything. Ah, but where I think it won me over, like, what made me adopt it more, was in this

understanding it has of the codebase, right? Being able to ask AI things about the codebase and it being able to answer me based on what is actually implemented, like. And when I say things about the codebase, they are really product questions, right? For example, ah, what happens if such a user performs such an action? And then it finds the implementation of this action and tells me exactly, right, as if it were reverse engineering, like, it writes the product through the code.

And do you have a PO, PM role there, something like that, that passes the requirements to you, or do you yourselves build that part and then, based on that, already code?

Yes, we do, we have PM and designer.

And then how do they pass the information to you?

Yeah, usually a problem document comes. Yeah, it is not exactly a formal requirements elicitation document, a problem document. Yeah, and then in this document there are some specific instructions. Ah, we need it to do this, do that, but there are no details. Then the details are built in interaction with the engineering people, like. And also with the designers, right? When they are product changes, anyway, graphical ones. We also have the flows there in the design and refine from that.

But do you use this documentation as input for AI?

Not much, I think this documentation usually comes at a very high level. Ah, and then these refinements happen more in, like, meetings, conversations on Slack, things like that. Yeah, so it does not really generate an artifact detailed enough to put directly into the AI, you know?

How do you receive, then, some task, let's say, that you have to send, that you use it for AI?

Yeah, the engineering team creates it itself. Yeah, for example, then, we have the milestone that we need the user to log in, for example. Then the engineering team will, from that, make the login and then we detail it: "Ah, it will be an email field, a password field, okay?" Then we will create the task, create the email field, create the password field, integrate with the backend, okay? Show error message, all of that.

All of this manually? Without using AI?

Yeah, I think so, okay? There are MCPs that we can use nowadays to generate tasks, but I think today it is more normal.

And how do you feel using AI? Do you prefer working with it or more like it was before there in your old flow?

I like working with it. Ah, like, when I use AI I am usually pretty happy. My problems with it are other ones.

And are there situations in which it does not help as expected or in which it cannot do a certain task well?

Yes, there are times when it gets in the way, in my opinion, like. Ah, which are moments that are usually when there is ambiguity, right? I think they do not deal very well with ambiguity because AI does not ask questions, right? Unless you are in a planning mode, it does not ask questions. So if it found, I do not know, you want to implement something, it found two components that could be it, it will choose one, it may be the wrong one. And it will not ask: "Look, I found two, which one do you prefer, which one is better?" No, it will choose one and do this. And sometimes I go through several iterations like this, okay, enough, I will do it myself.

And what type of practice or guidance or some tool do you think could improve the use of AI? What do you think is still missing to use it better in development?

I think it is more, ah, I think today we have context limitations, right? Because a person will always have a much greater context than an agent. Ah, and I think there is a lot that is in the historical context. And nowadays we do not have historical documentation, right? For example, ah, I will make this decision here, because, I do not know, we have a tight deadline, so I will choose this to the detriment of that. Ah, AI will never have this information and sometimes this information is important. Yeah, I do not know how to tell you how this interaction is done, but I think this is a context that is quite missing.